

ferent types of action. In order to control the operation of such nested tasks, you need to be able to 'Start', 'Stop', 'Pause' or 'Enable/Disable' a task. These tools are likely to be useful later, when you need to create really complex tasks.

Internet functions: These functions can be used to make or terminate a connection to the Internet and perform basic tasks such as checking your mail box or starting a file download or upload operation via HTTP or FTP.

Create your first macro

To get an idea of how a macro is created, let's start by creating a macro that fires up Outlook Express and sends a test message to a specified address when you press the [Ctrl] + [Shift] + [B] key combination.

Use the 'New Task' button ([Ctrl] + [N]) to start the 'Task Wizard' and enter a name for the macro in the 'Task Name' field. You can then skip to step 4 to define the trigger that we decided on earlier—[Ctrl] + [Shift] + [B]. Before we start with step 5 ('Task Steps'), you should define all the actions that need to take place in order to complete this task. For this you should first go through the entire process manually and make a list of each step involved.

For our task, the process list would look something like this:

- u Start Outlook Express
- u Select the appropriate account from the 'Identity Login' screen
- u Key in the password for the account
- u Create a 'New Message'
- u Enter the e-mail address as required
- u State the subject for the e-mail
- u Enter the body text for the message
- u Send the message
- u Minimise the Outlook Express window

Some other Automation Tools



Although we decided to work with Macro Angel v1.5.2, there are several other automation utilities that can get the job done. They are all available in the Macro Mania section on the System Tools CD this month. But you might want to visit their home pages for version updates.

AceMacro v2.0 - www.hiteksoftware.com
 MouseAssist 2.0 - www.mindmaker.com
 AutoMate 4.5n - www.unisyn.com
 Macro Magic 4.1r - www.iolo.com
 WinScheduler v4.61 - www.pitrinec.com

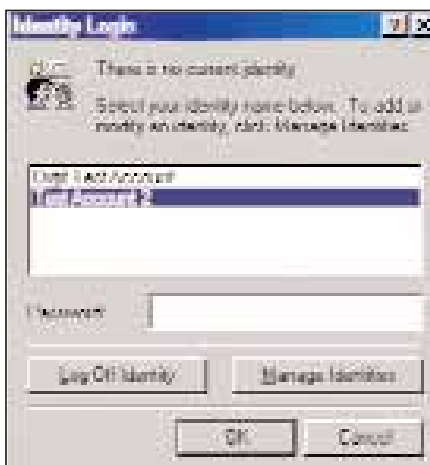
Once we have this listed, creating the Tasks Steps is quite simple. Our first macro can be broken up into four main stages as follows:

Stage 1: Start up e-mail client

To start Outlook Express, go to **Misc > Start an Application** and select the path to the Outlook Express executable from the box that pops up. In this case you would select **C:\Program Files\Outlook Express\msimn.exe**.

Stage 2: Log into e-mail account

Selecting the right e-mail account is done by going to **Misc > Record Events** and recording mouse movements that will click on the account that you want to log into. The password can be entered using the 'Enter Keystroke' action.



Use the Event Recorder to select your e-mail identity and enter the password

Stage 3: Create and send the e-mail
 This stage can be completed in most part with the 'Keystroke' action. Just use the [Ctrl] + [N] command in Outlook Express to create a 'New Message'. The e-mail address, subject line and body text can also be entered using this action. Finally, you can send the e-mail using the [Alt] + [S] command in the 'New Message' window.

You might want to use 'Time Delays' between the actions just to make sure the text goes where you intend it to. You wouldn't want the address to end up in the subject line field and cause an error when you try to send the e-mail.

Stage 4: Minimise the e-mail client

This is really easy to do with the **Windows > Minimise a window** action, but you will need to specify the title of the Outlook Express window. You can either type this yourself or just select it (by double-clicking) from amongst the windows listed in the

Free your Mind!

Here are five tasks that you shouldn't waste your time with. Just go ahead and automate them pronto!



Checking e-mail: Let your PC connect to the Internet, Send/Receive your e-mail and disconnect, all on its own.



File backups: Set up automatic backups of files and folders according to a pre-determined schedule.



System cleaning: Purge your system of temporary files and empty your Recycle Bin regularly.



Web site updates: Download and upload your Web site files automatically via an FTP client on schedule.



Standard e-mail responses: Create an e-mail template for every occasion. Make your own macros for standard greetings, e-mail taglines and more.



Select the window that you want to minimise

'Window List' on the right. Just remember, the window must already be open in the background for it to appear in this list.

We are done with making our first macro and have familiarised ourselves with a number of different types of actions as well as some basic flow control techniques. The macro is now ready to run and can be executed at any time by pressing [Ctrl] + [Shift] + [B]. Just remember that Macro Angel should be running in your system tray.

A little practice with these commands and techniques and you'll be able to automate even the most complex tasks. Remember that you should try and construct a macro that gets the job done in as few steps as possible. Having done that you can relax, put your legs up and leave things to your PC and the autopilot. ■

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